

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 15

Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1946-1949

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage

Nyanza Province, Southwestern Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): THE CIRCUMCISION CEREMONY

An *enkuri* (cf. *ogokura*, to cry) is a would-be novice who, when the circumciser is about to set to work, cries out or moves or touches him. This disgrace is hard to live down. Boys who cry are not common, but most of my informants could give the names of two or three. The circumciser does not operate but strikes the *enkuri* sharply with the handle of the knife, saying 'You have spoilt my tree'.¹ He also utters curses such as "Your wife will die. Your children will die." The onlookers remain silent. On leaving the tree, the boy is detained by the bystanders, while a message is sent to his home that a goat must be brought for redemption. When the goat is received – probably in the afternoon – the *enkuri* can be operated on in privacy, and can go home. Then, too, the tree under which he disgraced himself will be made fit for use once more; but meanwhile it has been 'spoilt' and the circumciser has to continue work under another.

152
[Drives And Emotions](#)

304
[Body Alterations](#)

558
[Downward Mobility](#)

782
[Prayers And Sacrifices](#)

783
[Purification And Atonement](#)

881
[Puberty And Initiation](#)

When one or two groups of novices have been dealt with, the circumciser leads off the singing of the *esimbore*.² The escorts at first answer with the refrain (*Oyo, oyo-o-o!*) and then take over the singing.³ The song enumerates, as will be seen, things unmentionable for initiated males, except as deliberate or joking insults.

304
[Body Alterations](#)

533
[Music](#)

881
[Puberty And Initiation](#)

903
[Interlinear Translations](#)

Baisia ake bororo bwabarire!	Uncircumcised little boys ha	304
Isamokami oirire mboro chiaito;	The circumciser has taken ou	Body Alterations
Oturerwe itumo na nguba mbibo.	He has made you a spear and	
Orwane Sigisi, orwane Sigisi!	Fight the Kipsigis, fight th	533
Orwane Bosoba, orwane Bosoba!	Fight the Abasuba, fight the	Music
Baisia ake, e-e-		
e, bororo bwabarire!	Uncircumcised little boys have had pain!	881
Isono ria ng'ina, isono ria ng'ina.	Mother's clitoris, mother's	Puberty And Initiation
Oboya bwa ng'ina, oboya bwa ng'ina.	Mother's pubic hair, mother'	
Baisia ake etomba, tomba ng'ina!	Uncircumcised little boys, c	903
Baisia ake bororo bwabarire!	Uncircumcised little boys ha	Interlinear Translations

On the slow homeward journey, the older lads lead the way and keep up the singing at the top of their voices. Processions of novices must keep to the bush and not pass through any homesteads. When the mother hears the eagerly awaited sound of singing in the distance, she begins to trill and sing her son's praises. 'My eldest (or youngest or middle) child, my child whom I bore in trouble! You have done well for me, my child!' Co-wives and neighbouring women join in, and gather to watch at a vantage point. As sight of the novice is forbidden to women, they retire when the procession approaches. High excitement prevails. Women give vent to their emotions by throwing up their arms, dancing, singing, and trilling. The mother may laugh and cry as she calls over all the names she gave her son at birth: 'My Kibagendi, my Gisiora, Ngota, Ochora, my Nyarimbani! My child whom I bore at midnight! My child whom I bore at Mwogeto!'

152
Drives And Emotions

533
Music

784
Avoidance And Taboo

881
Puberty And Initiation

The returning novices are bound not for the seclusion hut but for a resting-place on the outskirts of the homestead, usually near the granaries, where there is shelter from sun or rain. The procession remains in the bush while the novices who are to be secluded in the homestead are led to this spot; then it goes on its way until all the novices have been left at their respective places, when it disperses. During the couple of hours he is allowed to rest, a novice may relieve his feelings by crying or groaning, 'as long as he does not cry out too loud'. Boys or girls may visit him there and exchange a few words, but married people – most especially the  16 parents – must keep away. If the boy is bleeding very seriously, the father might feel justified in going to look at him, but the mother avoids him at all costs, and cannot do more than consult a diviner, leaving any necessary nursing to other women.

152
Drives And Emotions

343
Outbuildings

574
Visiting And
Hospitality

784
Avoidance And Taboo

828
Ethnopsychology

866
Independence Training

881
Puberty And Initiation

¹Some informants insist that at such times a circumciser refers to the tree as 'manger' (*orotuba*). It will be seen in Part II that girls are circumcised sitting on a manger (made from a tree trunk).

²*Esimbore* is one of a small number of Gusii songs distinguished by having its own proper name; another, for instance, is *esita*, sung after killing an enemy.

³In this, as in all the songs to be given, the refrain is repeated in chorus after every line, the lines themselves being sung solo. Some songs have a refrain at the beginning as well as at the end of each line.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)